where Chanakya had once taught, was sacked by the Hunas around 470 AD. Over the next few decades they pushed the Gupta defences back into the Gangetic valley. A rump empire would remain for several generations, but the glory days were gone.

In the centuries that followed, a number of powerful kingdoms rose and fell in northern India—the Palas of Bengal, Harsha of Thaneshwar and so on. The city of Pataliputra slowly went into decline and was replaced by Kannauj (now a small town in Uttar Pradesh). Nonetheless, most things drifted along. Both Nalanda and Ujjain remained important centres of learning. Thinkers like Bhaskara and Varahamihira made great contributions to mathematics and astronomy. Chinese scholars continued to visit India to study Buddhism. The most prominent of these scholars was Xuan Zang who visited India in the seventh century, more than two hundred years after Fa Xian.

Like his predecessor, Xuan Zang (also spelled Hiuen-Tsang) made his way to India through Central Asia, which was then inhabited primarily by Buddhist and pagan Turks. He spent over a decade in the subcontinent during which he crisscrossed the Gangetic plains and went as far east as Assam. He even spent two years studying at Nalanda, which was then at the height of its fame.

One of the places he visited on these travels was Allahabad (then called Prayag). This town is near one of the most sacred sites in Hinduism—the ‘Triveni Sangam’ or the Mingling of Three Rivers. Two of the rivers are obvious: the sacred Ganga and the Yamuna. However, the factor that gives this spot a special significance is that the Saraswati is also said to flow underground and join the other two at this place. In this way, a primordial memory of the vanished river is kept alive. For a Hindu, the sins of a lifetime are washed away by taking a dip in the confluence of these rivers. It is especially auspicious to do this at the time of the Kumbh Mela, which is held here every twelve years.[19] This is part of a four-year cycle by which this event is held in turn in Ujjain, Haridwar, Nasik and Allahabad. However, it is the great Kumbh Mela of Allahabad that is the largest and most prestigious. The last time this festival was hosted in Allahabad in